The controversies surrounding Régis Renault

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As part of the structuring and recognition of MMA in France, certain actors have played a central role in its dissemination, while others have opposed this discipline. The example of Régis Renault perfectly illustrates these tensions, highlighting the divergent opinions between promoters of the practice and critics concerned with its social and cultural implications.

The main opponents to Renault's actions in the field of mixed martial arts (MMA) come primarily from two circles: on the one hand, journalists and various actors expressing principled hostility toward this discipline; on the other hand, former members of his organization or ex-students expelled for "inappropriate behavior." Among these detractors, Laurent Ripert, head of sports affairs at the Carpentras municipality, notably distinguished himself through repeated efforts to prevent the establishment of a Pankration club in the city.

The criticisms directed at Renault are structured around several axes. First, he is reproached for contributing to the normalization of violence, particularly among young people from disadvantaged backgrounds. According to his critics, some of his initiatives or creations could have encouraged aggressive behavior by normalizing physical confrontation or glorifying extreme competition. These critiques fit into a broader debate on the role of public figures and media in shaping the behavioral models of younger generations, and on how certain sports practices can influence perceptions of violence.

Next, some observers accuse him of promoting a resurgence of ancient combat games, seen as a return to practices considered archaic or barbaric. Inspired by ancient rituals and traditions, these games are sometimes interpreted as a form of violent nostalgia or a misuse of historical practices for entertainment purposes. Critics stress that, without an educational framework, these activities risk reinforcing a view of physical strength as the primary measure of social value, thus fueling concerns about their educational and moral implications.

In addition to these criticisms, according to former collaborators, there are allegations regarding supposed connections with controversial personalities, notably within motorcycle clubs. Some observers have also referred to him as a "guru" due to his interest

in occult sciences and esoteric practices, implying that he could exert a symbolic or ideological influence on those around him.

It should be noted, however, that no concrete or verifiable evidence has ever established Renault's direct involvement in illegal or marginal activities. Most accusations remain speculative or interpretative and should be treated with caution when assessing his role and actual impact.

At the same time, testimonies collected from former colleagues, students, and independent observers paint a very positive picture of Renault: a measured, sociable, honest, and benevolent man whose commitment appears primarily guided by educational and disciplinary values, far removed from any glorification of brutality. His initiatives are also praised for their social contributions, particularly among young people and disadvantaged communities, and some of his supporters do not hesitate to describe him as saintly or exemplary.

After years in the wilderness, pankration finally takes off. It is precisely at this moment that Régis Renault chooses to distance himself abruptly from it — a decision his friends and collaborators will deem irrational, leaving them with a bitter taste of betrayal.Years later, his former student and friend Saïd El Mekki will provide the explanation. In the late 1990s, Bertrand Boyer, an amateur investigator passionate about martial arts and European combat sports, begins researching brancaille. His inquiries quickly lead him to pankration and to Renault. Delving deeper, he uncovers Renault's troubled past and some compromising associations.

Alerted by his friend Jean-Paul Jimenez, Renault then makes a radical choice: to protect the image of pankration and that of his associates, he steps away from the French association he had founded and refocuses his efforts on international development through the IUPAD (International Union of Pankration & Assimilated Disciplines), which remains shielded from the virulent criticism prevalent in France.

But the internet changes everything, accelerating the spread of information. Connections between pankration and brancaille — the latter increasingly viewed as a "thug's discipline" — become more and more visible. Articles multiply on the subject. Overwhelmed by the phenomenon and by the ensuing slander directed at him personally, Renault eventually deletes the IUPAD website and severs all ties with pankration.Yet, according to Saïd El Mekki, Renault harbored no resentment. On the contrary: he had achieved his goal. He had successfully revived pankration and helped establish it as a

nationally recognized discipline in France.

This polarization of discourse illustrates the deeper tensions surrounding the institutionalization process of MMA in France. Between the desire to recognize this practice as a legitimate sporting expression and the persistent fear of societal deviation, the case of Renault crystallizes the contradictions of a broader debate on the place of controlled violence in contemporary sport. Critics highlight legitimate ethical, educational, and social concerns, while supporters emphasize his positive and humanistic contributions.

Thus, examining the controversies surrounding Renault and MMA underscores how the recognition of an emerging sport can provoke contrasting debates, blending subjective perceptions, societal concerns, and cultural stakes. Renault's image appears decidedly ambivalent: both influential and controversial, but also respected and admired, reminding us that any evaluation of his person and work must take into account this plurality of perspectives and the complexity of his impact.